

AFTERMATH

The smoke swirled in Ren's eyes as they fought their way out of the Portal, Arlo's voice echoing in the strange in-between world.

Ren felt a push as the Portal in Darkwell closed with a snap and for a horrifying moment, they thought they were going to get stuck.

But they didn't. The Portal released Ren and they staggered through the opening, gasping for breath, eyes reddened and stinging from the crossing.

"What was that?" they managed as they leaned heavily on the wall, the smell of burning sulphur all around them. After a few moments, Ren's eyes cleared and their breathing and thoughts began to stabilise.

"Arlo? Are you there? Are you okay? That was brutal..."

There was no answer.

Ren looked around, but the gallery was empty.

"Arlo?"

Nothing.

"That's strange," Ren mumbled.

They wafted away the remains of the foul-smelling smoke and vapours. They checked the floor for any sign of the missing compass, but there was no sign of that, either. Not to mention Afferflash the butterfly.

"It should have been here. *Arlo* should have been here," they muttered.

There was silence in the gallery, and Ren could hear their own heart pounding as dread settled on on them like an unwelcome cloak. They froze as a terrible thought crossed their mind.

He wouldn't... would he?

Ren groaned.

The Cottage. Arlo went to face whatever it was threatening his mum and brother in the mirror. And he's gone alone. Idiot!

The vision that had been shown to Arlo was clear - his mum and brother were in danger. They were in the cottage and they looked terrified, an unknown assailant pinning them to a wall.

Making a split-second decision, Ren set off from the gallery to the cottage, hurtling themselves down staircases and along corridors. They had never run so fast. Whoever had cornered Adelaide and Teddy were not to be trifled with, and although Arlo had amazed everyone at how quickly he had taken to Brightwell and the magic, he was still only a few weeks into his learning. He couldn't take someone on alone.

Ren made it to the garden wall of Arlo's cottage to find the door wide open. They stopped to catch their breath and think of a plan.

Just because I can't see anything, doesn't mean there's nothing there. Breathe, Ren. Steady yourself.

Regretting not going to get help before appearing at the cottage themselves, Ren crept up the garden path to the front door.

They listened hard, but there was nothing to hear.

Safe, then.

Ren peered around the open door.

Nothing.

They looked around. There were clear signs of a struggle, but nothing obvious to say where Adelaide and Teddy had gone.

Or where they were taken, they thought grimly.

The cottage was a wreck. Chairs had been tipped over, books and magazines were on the floor, and Teddy's pushchair was knocked sideways. It didn't look like anyone had 'gone quietly'. These were signs of a struggle and Ren had to push dark thoughts from their mind.

I'm going to be no help if I'm not with it. I have to hope everyone is okay.

Ren took a deep breath and tried to sense the energy left in the room, aiming to see whether Arlo had been part of the struggle.

Even if I could get a sense where they'd gone...

"Naelyvren Voth'rai."

The spell rippled across the cottage, allowing Ren to glimpse the auras of those last in the room. Adelaide's was clear and still - the air shimmered in the palest of blues, and Ren could smell the sweet scent of baking. They concentrated harder, then another energy signal came forward - the orange and red energy of Teddy, playful but then laced with fear.

But no Arlo.

Ren paused and concentrated. There *was* another energy signature they could sense, but it was like it had been ... *deleted* somehow. Written over. A palimpsest.

Someone is covering their tracks.

Ren backed out of the cottage, knowing clearly now that Arlo had not gone to the cottage when he stepped through the Portal... which left the question;

Where in all the realms was Arlo Thorne?